▶ BIHAR

A NEET Twist

Proxy candidates at exam centres prove the 'solver' mafia is intact—and gaming biometrics

By **Amitabh Srivastava**

ONLY WEEKS AFTER A PAPER LEAK forced a retest of the NEET exam for undergraduate medical courses, the arrest of nine 'solvers' in Bihar shows even the June 21 retake may have been compromised. The arrested include not just the 'proxies' and the original candidates, but 18 members of the biometric verification team. That shows examination fraud is evolving.



PTI

▼ **ACTION REPLAY** Proxy candidates in police custody, Lakhisarai, Jun. 22

As a senior officer of the Economic Offences Unit (EOU) described it to INDIA TODAY, the biometric team authenticated the credentials of the genuine candidate, who remained outside the exam hall. Then, the alleged impersonators entered with a forged Aadhaar and admit card on which the photograph had been altered while retaining the original biometrics. Aadhaar-linked verification, with biometrics, had of late become the tool of choice for authorities—in the belief that it guaranteed against proxies. In Bihar, the technology was not defeated—the people operating it were bought over. The EOU is now seeking details of the entity entrusted with the biometrics. The other dramatis personae are depressingly familiar—students or interns at medical colleges in Bihar and beyond, besides of nursing, pharma and Ayush. A single impersonation could earn the proxy Rs 10-15 lakh, while the middlemen arranging it charged candidates Rs 40-50 lakh.

Takeaways

- **Police nab 30 accused at three exam centres**
- **Proxy 'solvers' were only one link in chain**
- **The biometrics team had been compromised**

The episode revives memories of the 2024 NEET paper leak that had led sleuths to an exam mafia operating out of Hazaribagh in neighbouring Jharkhand. From the looks of it, the malaise is far from cured. ■

By **Prasad Nichenametla**

A POPULAR FAST FOOD HALT NEAR CHARMINAR frying its lip-smacking chicken in oil as dense and dark as engine lubricants, coating it with prohibited colours for that reddish lure. Elsewhere, samosas being made using spoiled ingredients. Stale, raw meat attracting flies, cockroaches scampering around shelves, doubtful water, food items as expired as operational licences—the sights that awaited a new posse of 'food police' at restaurants in Hyderabad could have put them off food for good. Not just street food—elite restaurants, a few established houses among them, were not entirely squeaky-clean either.

Renowned for its biryani, haleem and local culinary fare, Hyderabad is a foodie's paradise. But an inspection of its restaurant kitchens is also revealing much that's unappetising. Commercial food hygiene is usually the remit of food safety and civic authorities, but these sins are being uncovered, booked and brought to public notice by a police special unit formed in March: the Hyderabad Food Adulteration Surveillance Team (H-FAST). The brains behind the drive is a man known to take no prisoners: city police commissioner V.C. Sajjanar, who made national news in 2019 when four accused in a veterinarian's rape-murder were shot dead in an encounter in Cyberabad, then his charge.

TONNES OF 'JUNK' FOOD

In the past three months or so, H-FAST is on an encounter of another sort. It has seized and discarded 122 tonnes of hazardous/adulterated food materials, including 27,024 kg of impure ginger-garlic paste, 25,845 kg of chemically ripened fruits, 60+ tonnes of discarded chicken waste and substandard meat, 9,260 kg of stale/adulterated pickles, 4,030 kg of adulterated khoya, 3,897 kg of spurious tea powder and 3,260 kg of iffy cream. The visuals from the 'Customers Not Allowed' sections of quite a few eateries are horrifying their patrons.

The revelations from H-FAST on local food manufacturing units, especially in the old city, are no less shocking. In one of their raids at a unit at Gagan-